

Flying Boats and Amphibians

The 1930s was the “Golden Age” for flying boats, with airlines operating large, luxurious machines that were fitted with beds and offered silver service dining. Some of the aircraft could touch down on land or on water. However, one of the consequences of World War II was that a large number of runways were built all over the world. As a result, the faster, more economical landplanes soon rendered the flying boat obsolete.



△ Saro A.19 Cloud 1930

Origin UK

Engine 3 x 340 hp Armstrong-Whitworth Serval III air-cooled 10-cylinder 2-row radial

Top speed 118 mph (190 km/h)

Descended from the Saro A.17 Cutty Sark amphibian, 22 A.19 Clouds were built and used mostly by the RAF, although a few were operated as civilian aircraft. One was sold to the Czechoslovakian state airline and its fuselage survives at the Prague Aircraft Museum, Kbely.



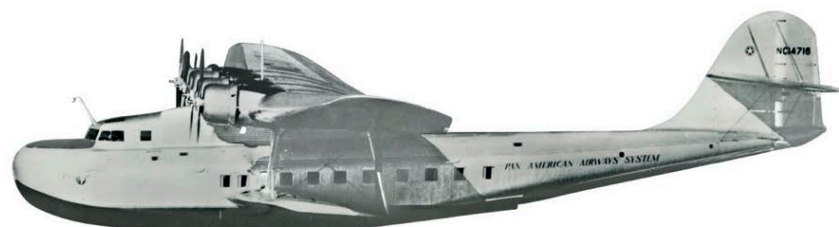
△ Savoia-Marchetti S.66 1932

Origin Italy

Engine 3 x 750 hp Fiat A.24R liquid-cooled V-12

Top speed 164 mph (264 km/h)

A large flying boat notable for its twin-hull design, the S.66 was designed as an airliner, although during the war it was used for search and rescue. Unusually, the flight deck was located in the center section of the wing, while all the passenger seats were in the hulls.



△ Martin M130 1935

Origin USA

Engine 4 x 950 hp Pratt & Whitney Twin Wasp air-cooled 14-cylinder 2-row radial

Top speed 180 mph (290 km/h)

Intended to service Pan Am's Pacific routes, only three M130s were built. Like the later Boeing 314s, all were named “clipper” (China Clipper, Hawaii Clipper, and Philippine Clipper). One flew the first trans-Pacific airmail service, and all were lost in fatal accidents.



▷ Grumman J2F-6 Duck 1936

Origin USA

Engine 1,050 hp Wright Cyclone air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 190 mph (304 km/h)

Although it may look like a biplane on an amphibious float, the Duck is actually more like a flying boat, because the single float is blended into the fuselage. The Duck was used by all branches of the US military and Coast Guard, and also Argentina, Colombia, Mexico, and Peru.

▽ Grumman JRF-5 Goose 1937

Origin USA

Engine 2 x 450 hp Pratt & Whitney Wasp Junior air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 264 mph (424 km/h)

Initially intended to be used as a “commuter” aircraft between Long Island and New York, the Goose proved to be a rugged and reliable amphibian, and was used for both military and civil (as the G-21) applications. Around 340 machines were built.

